

Interview Thesis Brief

Director, AI Operations

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<https://russelldudek.github.io/Ontra/>

Candidate thesis

Turn each AI intervention into a precedent the next team can trust.

Why this role matters now

Ontra's public identity is AI-native and its products convert unstructured information into insight, action, and automation. The internal operating opportunity is to bring comparable discipline to how AI changes work across departments—without confusing public product capability with private employee workflow maturity.

Actual work

Build the mechanism between AI ambition and adopted work: qualify demand, shape the roadmap, implement bounded workflows, retain human authority, integrate governance, develop advocates, establish community and training cadence, evaluate tools and vendors, and prove value through changed work.

Operating tensions

Central coherence vs. department ownership. Shared standards must help local leaders own outcomes.

Speed to proof vs. trust by design. Experiments move faster when authority, access, escalation, and evidence are explicit.

Experimentation vs. reusable capability. A local win should leave behind patterns without forcing false uniformity.

Executive ambition vs. frontline habit. Adoption is retained behavior, not attendance or license activation.

AI Operating Precedent

Each case records six clauses: Work, Value, Human authority, Boundary, Adoption, and Evidence. It resolves to Discovery candidate, Bounded practice, or Reusable precedent. The accountable workflow owner remains visible throughout.

Evidence, entry priorities, and executive questions

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Verified evidence map

Vape-Jet: direct AI-first operating transformation across functions, systems, telemetry, standard work, training, and accountability.

DudeWorth: direct AI-readiness and agentic workflow design spanning value, feasibility, context, human judgment, governance, evaluation, and adoption.

Amazon: launch execution, customer-backward cadence, visibility, escalation, and standard work at meaningful operating scale.

Compunetics: technical translation, quality systems, process controls, root cause, and high-reliability cross-functional execution.

120-day priorities

Read the work (1–30): map demand, active experiments, systems, constraints, authority, and evidence.

Install the mechanism (31–60): establish intake, precedent clauses, intervention patterns, review boundaries, and enablement cadence.

Prove cases (61–90): run bounded implementations and instrument value, trust, adoption, and learning.

Make learning compound (91–120): publish reviewed precedents, strengthen advocates, and recommend the next roadmap from evidence.

Executive questions

1. Where does AI demand enter today, and what makes an opportunity worthy of centralized attention?
2. Which decisions must remain visibly human even when AI performs more of the preparatory work?
3. What has made current AI adoption persist—or decay—after initial enthusiasm?
4. Which boundaries currently create confidence, and which create avoidable friction?
5. What would make leadership say after six months that AI Operations changed how the company works?